

New Grad Job Search Kit

Application tracker, cost-of-living-adjusted offer comparison, and word-for-word salary negotiation scripts.

This product contains educational information and templates. Nothing here is professional, legal, tax, or investment advice. Numbers in every worked example are illustrations of a method, not predictions or guarantees.

01 Total compensation, not just salary

A job offer is rarely just a number. Base salary is the largest piece for most early-career roles, but signing bonuses, annual bonus targets, equity, retirement matching, health insurance quality, and remote flexibility all have real dollar value -- and cost of living can silently erase or amplify a salary difference between two cities. Comparing offers on base salary alone is the single most common mistake new graduates make, and it's an easy one to fix with a few extra minutes of arithmetic.

What to actually collect for each offer

- Base salary (annual, before tax)
- Signing bonus (one-time)
- Target annual bonus, as a percent of base -- and whether it is typically paid in full
- Equity value, if any, and its vesting schedule (a 4-year vest with a 1-year cliff is very different from immediate vesting)
- Employer 401(k)/retirement match, as a percent of salary
- Health insurance: your monthly premium contribution and the deductible
- Cost of living in the job's city relative to your current one

02 Worked example: comparing two real offers

Offer A: \$95,000 base in a high cost-of-living city with a cost-of-living index of 180 (relative to a baseline of 100).
Offer B: \$72,000 base in a moderate cost-of-living city with an index of 105. On base salary alone, Offer A looks like the clear winner by \$23,000 a year.

COST-OF-LIVING ADJUSTMENT FORMULA

COL-adjusted value = $\text{Salary} \times (\text{Baseline index} / \text{City index})$

Use 100 as your baseline (your current city, or a reference city)

Worked example: adjusting both offers to the same baseline (index 100)

Offer A: $\$95,000 \times (100 / 180) = \$52,777.78$ adjusted value

Offer B: $\$72,000 \times (100 / 105) = \$68,571.43$ adjusted value

Adjusted difference: Offer B is worth \$15,793.65 MORE

in real purchasing power, despite a \$23,000 lower sticker salary.

This is the single most important calculation in this kit. A cost-of-living index isn't something you need to invent -- publicly available indexes (search "cost of living index [city name]") give a reasonable relative number for this comparison. The adjustment doesn't replace judgment about career growth, team, or role -- it just makes sure the dollar comparison you're weighing that judgment against is an honest one.

03 Salary negotiation: word-for-word scripts

Negotiating your first offer is uncomfortable precisely because it's unfamiliar, not because it's unreasonable -- most employers expect it and build room into the initial number. These scripts are starting points, not something to read verbatim; adjust the tone to match how you actually talk.

Pushback: "This is our standard offer for new grads."

"I understand there's a standard band for this level, and I want to be respectful of that. Based on [specific research: a published range, a comparable offer, a skill you bring], is there flexibility within or above that band, particularly on [base salary / signing bonus]?"

Pushback: "We don't have budget to move on salary."

"I appreciate that constraint. If base salary is fixed, is there room to discuss a signing bonus, an accelerated first review, or additional PTO to help close the gap?"

Pushback: "This is already a competitive offer."

"I agree it's a strong offer, and I'm genuinely excited about the role. I do have [a competing offer / market research] suggesting a range of [\$X-\$Y] for this position, and I wanted to see if there's room to move closer to that before I make a final decision."

Pushback: "We need an answer by end of day."

"I want to give this the consideration it deserves, and I'm very interested. Would [48-72 hours] be possible so I can finalize my decision properly? I want to come back with a clear yes."

Pushback: "Can you share your other offers/numbers?"

"I'd rather keep other conversations confidential, but I can share that I'm evaluating offers in the [\$X-\$Y] range and wanted to see where there might be flexibility here."

Accepting, once you're satisfied

"Thank you for working with me on this -- I'm excited to accept. Could you send the updated offer in writing so I can confirm everything before my start date?" Always get the final numbers in writing before resigning from a current role or declining other offers.

04 Application tracker template

Track every application in one place so follow-up never depends on memory. Recreate this as a spreadsheet with these columns:

- Company / Role / Location
- Date applied
- Application source (referral, job board, career fair, cold application)
- Status (applied / phone screen / interview / offer / rejected)
- Next action & date (e.g., "follow up if no response by [date]")
- Contact name & email, if known
- Notes (salary range mentioned, culture impressions, red flags)

A good rule of thumb: if you haven't heard back within 7-10 business days of applying, a short, polite follow-up email is appropriate and reflects well on you, not poorly.

05 Research before every interview

1. Read the company's most recent public news or press release -- shows you did homework beyond the job posting.
2. Understand the product or service well enough to ask one specific, informed question about it.
3. Check the interviewer's background (LinkedIn or similar) for a genuine point of connection -- shared school, prior company, shared interest.
4. Prepare 2-3 specific questions that couldn't be answered by reading the website (team structure, what success looks like in 6 months, biggest current challenge for the team).
5. Know your own story: a tight 60-90 second answer to "tell me about yourself" that connects your background directly to this specific role.

06 Offer evaluation checklist

& Total compensation calculated, not just base

Include signing bonus, target bonus, equity, and retirement match in your comparison, not just the headline salary number.

& Cost of living adjusted

Use the formula in Section 2 before comparing offers across different cities -- a bigger number in an expensive city can be a smaller number in real terms.

& Growth trajectory considered

A lower starting offer with a clearer path to promotion or skill growth can outperform a higher offer with a flat trajectory over a 3-5 year horizon.

& Everything confirmed in writing

Verbal promises about raises, promotions, or flexibility should be reflected in the written offer letter before you sign, not left as a handshake understanding.

